Neil Kester, PMP, DASSM

kesterne1@gmail.com | +18042450085 | www.linkedin.com/in/neilkester/ |
github.com/nkester | www.nkester.com

PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY

As a certified Project Management Professional and Scrum Master with a BS in Civil Engineering and an MS in Systems Engineering, I am focused on providing customers with data driven analysis to support their decision cycle. I have over 12 years' experience building data solutions and interactive tools in R and SQL that have generated acclaim and recognition from C-Suite level decision makers. Over the last decade as a data scientist, my evaluations have consistently placed me in the top 10 percent of my peers, earning me early promotions and advanced job placement. I have led multiple full stack analytic development teams to deliver value to customers through highly technical solutions on time and exceeding expectations through the application of the software development lifecycle and Agile Software Development approaches. Experienced with both AWS and GCP, as well as secured Kubernetes platforms like RedHat's OpenShift, I understand cloud architecture, open-source frameworks, and Software Systems Engineering. Consistently hungry to learn more, I actively pursue additional certifications and independent technical projects to ensure I am prepared to provide value to my customers' future needs.

CORE COMPETENCIES

- **Functional:** Open-source Frameworks, Google Cloud Platform, Amazon Web Services, Kubernetes, Git-Ops, Agile Software Development, Graph Theory and Graph Databases, Relational Databases (PostgreSQL), Micro-Services Architectures, Data Modeling, Data Visualization, Problem Formulation, Value Delivery, and Machine Learning.
- **Behavioral:** Active Listening, Decision-Making, Resilience, Interpersonal Communication.
- **Professional:** Mentorship, Systems Thinking, Strategic Awareness, and Stakeholder Communication.

WORK EXPERIENCE

United States Army | Various Locations 2006 - Present

Department Director - University Department of Operations Sciences (2025 – Present)

- Directed an eleven-person team, mentoring and guiding them to provide relevant and timely data and analytic education to the Army's logisticians and data scientists.
- Saved the Army over $16 M in tuition costs and 140 man years of lost productivity by leading a team that delivered graduate-level analytics education to employees instead of a full time private graduate program.

Department Director - Assessments and Analysis (2022 – 2025)

- Directed a six-person team of data analysts and business analysts that served as business consultants, solving business problems of interest to the CEO and his senior executives.
- Reduced the organization's annual funding request by 10% by transforming capital allocation into a data-centric model that prioritized efforts, clarified dependencies, and expanded leader decision space.
- Reduced initial budget creation time by 80% by building an R optimization model and interactive R Shiny app that helped finance experts navigate complex legal requirements.
- Reduced employee lockouts by 80% by leading an Agile team that built tools and processes to improve security staff visibility, control, and operations.

Senior Technical Program Manager / Senior Data Scientist (2019 – 2022)

- Led a four-person full-stack team that built an AWS-deployed analytic tool, reducing medical advisers' research and synthesis time from one week to hours for complex board-level population health questions. Through servant leadership within the team, as the Software System Engineer and team lead, we planned, executed, and deployed the tool using a microservices architecture, deployed through GitLab CI/CD pipelines executing

automated unit testing and deploying validated artifacts to a secure Amazon Web Services environment. By implementing traditional Scrum SDLC approaches, I led the team to rapidly develop capabilities, execute user tests, and deploy working solutions rapidly.
- Cut weekly project status meetings from 2 hours to 1 while improving effectiveness through Agile practices and automated Jira dashboards that highlighted impediments and decision points.
- Architected production-grade refactoring of a mission-critical R analytic application, reducing edge-condition failures to graceful, well-articulated events that occurred less than 0.5% of the time. Transitioned the codebase to functional programming in R, implemented Test Driven Design, and engineered container-based GitLab CI/CD pipelines that eliminated breaking merge requests, exposed latent logic errors, ensured 100% customer alignment, and created a resilient foundation for scaling and troubleshooting.
- Provided more than 300 data scientists, deployed across the globe in austere and highly regulated environments with a secure analytics platform that allowed them to develop and deliver meaning insights at speed and scale.

Data Science Team Lead (2018)

- Expanded data coverage from 1% to 85% and reduced processing time from one week to 60 seconds through a mission-critical R-based ETL pipeline that built the data underpinnings of our data-driven operations.
- Contributed tens of millions of records to custom data warehouses that maintained data security and quality standards and supported self-service frameworks for operations analysts to generate novel insights.
- Improved marketing analysis team efficacy by 60% by building Agile data tools that integrated field reports with existing data to accelerate operational recommendations.
- Uncovered previously unknown connections between market segments through Social Network Analysis (SNA), graph theory, and data visualization by leveraging vast volumes of data from disparate sources.

Independent Technical Projects

- Bare-Metal Kubernetes Home Laboratory | Talos Linux, Helm, GitOps, Kubernetes. Architected and deployed a resilient, three-node bare-metal cluster to run containerized analytic tools, supported by Google GenAI tools.
  - https://github.com/nkester/Homelab/tree/Homelab_2026
- Automated Weather Station Application | JavaScript, REST APIs, HTML/CSS. Engineered a custom full-stack web application to ingest, parse, and visualize real-time environmental data streams.
  - https://github.com/nkester/Kester-Weather-Station

CERTIFICATIONS

- Disciplined Agile Senior Scrum Master (**DASSM**)
- Project Management Professional (**PMP**)
- Google Cloud Generative AI Leader
- Udacity Intro to Machine Learning with TensorFlow
- TS/SCI Security Clearance
- INFORMS CAP-X (in progress – Aug 2026)

TECHNICAL SKILLS

- R (12 yrs - Expert)
- Python (3 yrs - Intermediate)
- MS Excel (Expert)
- MS PowerPoint (Expert)
- MS Word (Expert)
- SQL (4 yrs - Intermediate)
- JSON / YAML (4 yrs)
- Ontologies / Taxonomies
- Graph Theory / Neo4J

EDUCATION

Master of Science (MS), Systems Engineering | Johns Hopkins Whiting School of Engineering (2017 – 2021)

- Thesis research required engineering analytic tools to ingest, parse, and analyze deeply nested JSON data, generated by thousands of iterative simulation runs, executed as microsystems in Amazon We Services.

Master of Science (MS), Engineering Management | Missouri University of Science and Technology (2009 – 2010)

Bachelor of Science (BS), Civil Engineering | United States Military Academy (USMA) (2002 – 2006)